others of his ilk? Perhaps more than ever before? It's Rahul Gandhi. In mid-April, he made his third visit to Gujarat in 45 days, and set rolling a party revamp that seeks to strike at the root of its rot: the districts.

After the symbolism of choosing Gujarat for its AICC session (April 8-9), Rahul was back a week later to kickstart some action on the ground. Chosen teams have been spending up to five days every week since mid-April in the districts, interacting, eliciting points of view, identifying fresh local leadership and, most importantly, spotting BJP 'agents'. The decentralised approach comes not a moment too soon: grassroot workers, feeling directionless and unmotivated in the absence of a strong local tier of leadership, have lost connection with voters.

Takeaways

- **No credible, inspiring pan-Gujarat face. Those who represent social blocs**
- **The search has started at the grassroots. A panel will identify 50 promising faces**

That same paucity applies at the state level: there are no credible, inspirational, pan-Gujarat faces. "We are creating a profile of 45-50 leaders in each district," says an excited Solanki. By the time a five-member panel submits its exhaustive district-wise dossier in July, "they would have collectively interacted with 2,500-3,000 in each district," says Solanki, explaining why otherwise listless party offices are buzzing like beehives.

But the party's biggest challenge is a total disconnect with Gujarat's urban voters. Around 75 assembly seats are considered 'urban seats'. Of these, the Congress won only two in 2022 (even as it plunged to its worst-ever tally 17/182). Does this revamp address that failing? Many insiders feel the party's caste emancipatory language entirely bypasses this constituency, while no alternative outreach has been designed for them either.

The next test comes up in early 2026, with urban local bodies polls. Of late, these have set the tone for the assembly election. For instance, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) made its first impact in the Surat municipal corporation polls in 2021, before slicing off ever bigger pieces from the Congress pie. AAP's present eclipse offers an opening, as does widespread anti-incumbency against the BJP. But the Congress has to forget its knack of defeatism to cash in. ■

EXODUS AT TOP

The paucity of leadership owes to a string of big names defecting to BJP



Arjun Modhwadia: Ex-state party chief and OBC leader rejoined BJP in March 2024



Ambarish Der: The ex-MLA from Rajula joined BJP in March 2024



C.J. Chavda: Ex-chief whip and three-time MLA from Vijapur quit in 2024



Hardik Patel: Once the face of the Patidar agitation and state working president, Hardik joined BJP in June 2022

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

THE LOCAL ROOKS AND BISHOPS say please, let's do it. The grand old man says yes, okay, maybe. The grand nephew says yes, we must. The daughter says what, no, nothing like that. Seismographers wouldn't know how to parse the signals emerging from the Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar)—it's not quite a tectonic shift yet. But Sharad Pawar, 84, and a semi-retired supremo by his own description, is not one who speaks loosely. If he's hinting at a possible entente with estranged nephew and deputy CM Ajit Pawar, top honcho of the rival NCP, it must mean something.

A SURPRISE, OR IS IT?

So, what did the craftiest man of Maratha politics say actually that has set speculation swirling? It was classic Pawar. The words were cryptic, and sat right on the fence, leaving enough scope to alight on either side. He told media personnel that his daughter Supriya Sule and her cousin Ajit had to decide if the two NCPs needed to reunite—and that he "won't be surprised" if the idea came to fruition.

Earlier, in a newspaper interview, he had spoken of 'two views' in the party. One favoured reunion, and the other prescribed unconditional distance from the BJP so as to maintain ideological hygiene in the public eye. Sule, the MP from Baramati, has "taken a decision of sitting in the Opposition in Parliament", he said; the words "our thinking" implied endorsement.